

THE OFF-SEASON THAT NEVER ENDS



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For some cricketers, the off-season arrives between tours. For **Shikha Pandey**, it has stretched across years, interrupted only by short returns and longer silences. Yet the work never stopped, only the noise did.

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If you have followed Shikha Pandey's career over the years, you know that introspection comes tightly woven with excellence for the pace bowling veteran.

A voracious reader and one of the most curious minds in the game, Shikha is constantly searching for things, anecdotes, moments, and people who can inspire her and widen her horizons as both a player and a person. Many of those thoughts and learnings found their way into a diary and, eventually, into a blog named '*Accidentally Cheeku*'.

Her posts list several quotes and literary verses she draws strength from. But this one best epitomises Shikha's spirit itself: *Aut Viam Inventam Aut Faciam*, Latin for "I shall either find a way or make one".

Exiled from the national setup for reasons best known to those who chose to exclude her, the country's strongest pacer, physically and tactically, was left to make her own way on the fringes.

After a summer in which she bowled an all-time great delivery to dismiss Alyssa Healy in a T20I at the Gold Coast in 2021, Shikha was stunningly dropped in the run-up to the 2022 ODI World Cup, where India failed to advance to the knockouts.

Selectors went back to her for the 2023 T20